

Radical right, fragmentation, and government cohesion: a
comparative analysis

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Introduction

Since the early 1990s, radical right parties have become established actors in parliamentary democracies. While their electoral success has been widely studied, considerably less is known about the effects of their presence within institutions. In particular, it remains unclear whether their parliamentary presence affects the composition of governing coalitions, even when these parties do not enter government themselves. Existing research has shown that radical right parties can shape party competition, influence mainstream party positioning, and alter policy agendas, but comparative evidence on their consequences for coalition structure remains limited. This paper addresses that gap by examining the relationship between the parliamentary presence of radical right parties and the ideological range of coalition governments across European parliamentary democracies. The central question is whether the entry of radical right parties into parliament changes the logic of coalition formation by forcing mainstream actors to construct broader and more ideologically dispersed cabinets, or whether it instead encourages greater cohesion among governing parties. Building on theories of coalition formation and party system fragmentation, the paper tests three hypotheses: first, that radical right presence increases the ideological dispersion of governing coalitions; second, that this effect is stronger in more fragmented party systems; and third, that the relationship persists after endogeneity is addressed. Using cabinet-level data from European parliamentary democracies, the analysis combines ordinary least squares (OLS) models with a two-stage least squares (2SLS) design. The findings provide only limited support for the theoretical expectation. While bivariate models indicate a positive association between radical right presence in parliament and the ideological range of governments, this relationship disappears once structural controls are introduced. Moreover, the instrumental variable estimates reveal a negative and statistically significant effect, suggesting an outcome opposite to the initial expectation. These findings challenge the idea that the institutionalization of the radical right directly increases the heterogeneity of governing coalitions and instead highlight the importance of strategic and structural constraints in coalition formation.

Radical right parties and coalition formation

Coalition governments are not simply technical arrangements required by parliamentary arithmetic; they are also a central arena in which strategic interactions among parties can be observed. In multiparty systems, it is relatively rare for a single party to secure an outright parliamentary majority. As a result, interparty cooperation becomes a structural necessity for the formation of stable and functional governments. Understanding coalition politics, therefore, requires attention to the bargaining processes that occur before and after elections, when parties negotiate governing arrangements, policy priorities, and the distribution of office benefits (Curtin and Miller 2011). These negotiations are highly informative because they reveal which trade-offs parties are willing to accept and which partners they consider acceptable. In most Western democracies, government formation depends on cooperation among multiple parties (Blondel 1968). This is particularly true in proportional and mixed electoral systems, where party fragmentation makes single-party governments less likely. Coalition formation in these contexts usually rests on negotiated agreements that seek to reconcile different policy preferences while maintaining executive stability. As party system fragmentation increases, a larger number of actors become involved in cabinet bargaining, often producing greater ideological heterogeneity within governments (Ceron 2014). This creates a tension between the need for parliamentary majorities and the desire for ideological coherence. Traditional coalition theory predicts that parties will prefer minimal and ideologically compact coalitions (Schofield 1993), but empirical outcomes often deviate from this expectation because parties must also respond to institutional constraints, strategic incentives, and the exclusion of certain actors (Doring and Hellström 2013). These dynamics have become more salient with the transformation of European party systems and the rise of radical right parties. The success of these parties is not merely an electoral phenomenon; it reflects broader social, economic, and cultural changes within European democracies. Radical right parties are commonly associated with positions emphasizing order, hierarchy, exclusionary nationalism, and skepticism toward liberal and supranational institutions (Cole 2005). Although they vary across countries in organization and rhetoric, they often share a critical stance toward progressivism, immigration, and aspects of liberal democracy. Their rise has therefore contributed to a broader reconfigu-

ration of political competition. A growing body of literature argues that the success of radical right parties has pushed mainstream actors to adjust their rhetoric, reposition their policy stances, and reconsider their coalition strategies (Pickard, Efthymoulou, and Bove 2023). In this sense, the presence of the radical right can shift not only electoral competition but also the set of viable alliances. Mainstream parties face an increasingly salient dilemma: whether to cooperate with radical right parties and risk legitimacy or reputational costs, or to exclude them and thereby reduce the number of feasible coalition partners. This dilemma can have important consequences for coalition formation. Even when excluded from government, radical right parties may exert substantial institutional influence. Their parliamentary presence can constrain coalition-building options because many mainstream parties refuse cooperation with them due to ideological distance or reputational concerns (Bale 2003; Lange 2012). As a consequence, mainstream parties may be forced to build broader and less ideologically compact coalitions in order to secure legislative majorities. At the same time, the opposite dynamic is also plausible. The presence of radical right parties may induce mainstream actors to close ranks and form more internally cohesive governments as a strategic response to polarization and electoral threat (Minkenberg 2001). Most existing research has focused on the effect of radical right parties on electoral competition, agenda-setting, or policy change (Abou-Chadi and Krause 2020; Rooduijn and Akkerman 2015). By contrast, relatively little comparative attention has been devoted to their effect on the structure of governing coalitions. This omission is important because ideological heterogeneity within coalition governments has direct implications for governance. Broader ideological coalitions tend to complicate government formation, increase the need for detailed coalition agreements, and potentially reduce policy coherence and executive effectiveness (Ecker and Meyer 2015; Hyndman and Ray 2007; Fischer 2014). For this reason, examining whether radical right parties systematically alter the ideological range of governing coalitions offers a useful way to assess their institutional consequences. The broader theoretical issue, then, is whether the rise of radical right parties changes the logic of coalition formation. In relatively stable and homogeneous party systems, classical coalition models may still provide a reasonable approximation of governing dynamics. But in more fragmented and polarized systems, mainstream parties may be forced to adapt to the pressure exerted by radical challengers. This pressure may operate in two broad ways.

Exclusion of radical right parties may force mainstream actors to cooperate with ideologically distant partners in order to secure a majority. Alternatively, the presence of radical right actors may encourage mainstream parties to pursue tighter and more cohesive alliances in order to project unity and contain further fragmentation. These competing expectations motivate the hypotheses tested in this paper.

Hypotheses

Coalition governments are strategic arrangements, not merely mathematical combinations of seat shares. Understanding when and why they become more ideologically dispersed is central to theories of government formation. The parliamentary entry of radical right parties may reshape the bargaining environment by altering the set of acceptable coalition partners and increasing the strategic costs associated with particular alliances (Vachudova 2021). The first expectation is that the radical right's presence in parliament increases the ideological distance among governing parties. If mainstream actors refuse cooperation with radical right parties, they may be compelled to form governments with other partners that are further apart ideologically. In this sense, radical right presence may act as a centrifugal force, stretching coalition governments across a broader ideological spectrum. Moreover, exclusion of radical right parties is often driven not only by ideological incompatibility but also by reputational concerns, since cooperation with such parties may carry electoral and normative costs (Akkerman and Rooduijn 2014).

H1: The ideological distance between government parties is greater when a radical right party is present in parliament.

A second expectation concerns party system fragmentation. In highly fragmented systems, coalition bargaining already involves more actors and a broader set of possible combinations. If radical right presence further narrows the pool of acceptable partners, its effect on coalition heterogeneity should be amplified. Fragmented party systems may therefore intensify the impact of radical right parliamentary entry on coalition breadth.

H2: The effect of the presence of radical right parties on ideological distance is stronger when the party system is highly fragmented.

A third issue is endogeneity. Coalition outcomes may not only respond to party competition

but, over longer time horizons, may also shape voter preferences and party support. Broad or unstable governments, for instance, may generate dissatisfaction that benefits outsider parties, including those of the radical right. Although such feedback mechanisms are likely to unfold gradually, they complicate causal inference. To address this issue, the analysis uses the electoral vote share of radical right parties as an instrument for their parliamentary presence. This strategy builds on prior work distinguishing between electoral demand and actual legislative access (Valentim 2021; Abou-Chadi and Krause 2020; Golder 2003). Vote share reflects support for radical right parties, whereas parliamentary representation additionally depends on institutional thresholds and electoral rules.

H3: The parliamentary presence of radical right parties increases the ideological range within government coalitions even when accounting for endogeneity.

The IV approach is based on the claim that vote share should affect coalition structure primarily through its effect on whether radical right parties gain seats in parliament. This assumption cannot be tested directly and should therefore be treated cautiously. Additional limitations also need to be acknowledged. First, the analysis relies on static ideological measures that do not capture short-term changes in party positions. Second, ideology is modeled as unidimensional, which simplifies political competition and may miss issue-specific sources of heterogeneity. Third, radical right influence is operationalized as a binary measure of parliamentary presence, which does not distinguish among degrees of party strength or relevance. These caveats do not invalidate the analysis, but they do set limits on the interpretation of the results.

Data and Methods

The analysis draws on a cabinet-level dataset covering European parliamentary democracies from the early 1990s to the early 2020s, and the unit of analysis is the individual government. Each observation includes information on cabinet composition, party ideological positions, and electoral outcomes. The primary data source is the ParlGov database (Doring and Manow 2024), which was cleaned and merged across multiple files in order to construct measures of coalition ideological range and party system characteristics. The dependent variable is the ideological distance within governing coalitions. It is operationalized as the maximum range

between the ideological positions of parties in each cabinet on ParlGov’s 0–10 left–right scale. This measure captures the ideological heterogeneity of the governing coalition and serves as a proxy for the degree of compromise required for cabinet formation and maintenance. The key independent variable is the parliamentary presence of radical right parties. This is coded as a binary indicator equal to 1 when at least one radical right party is represented in parliament and 0 otherwise. The purpose of this measure is to capture whether the mere presence of a radical right alternative in the legislature affects coalition bargaining, regardless of whether such parties actually enter government (Golder 2016).

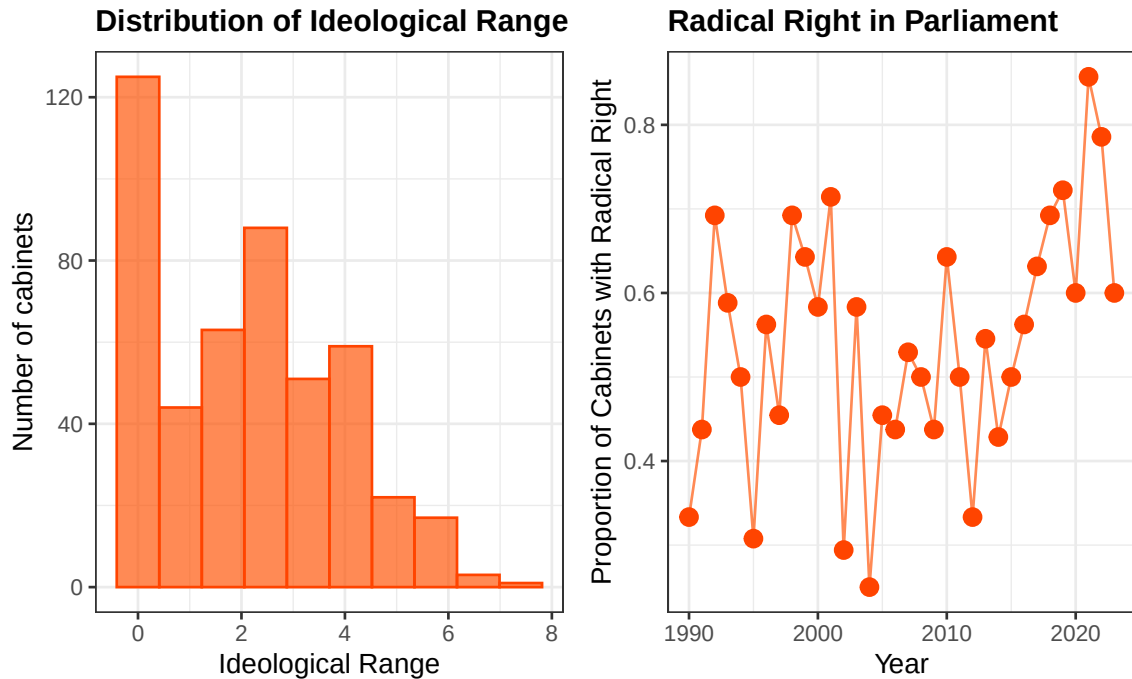


Figure 1: Distribution of dependent and independent variables

The models include several control variables in order to account for structural characteristics of party systems and coalition formation. Party system fragmentation is captured by the effective number of parties in parliament (ENP), measured using the Laakso and Taagepera index (Laakso and Taagepera 1979). Cabinet size measures the number of parties participating in government, which is generally expected to increase ideological heterogeneity because a larger number of actors must reach agreement (Indridason and Bowler 2014). The models also include a dummy variable identifying minimal winning coalitions (MWCs), defined

as governments that contain just enough parties to secure a parliamentary majority. Such coalitions are typically expected to be more ideologically compact because parties seek to maximize office benefits while limiting internal conflict (Martin and Stevenson 2001). Finally, ideological polarization is measured as the standard deviation of the ideological positions of all parliamentary parties, capturing the broader ideological structure of the party system (Jewitt and Goren 2016). To account for broader institutional and temporal dynamics, the models also include a linear time trend and country fixed effects. These controls capture historical changes as well as time-invariant cross-national differences in coalition norms, electoral rules, and institutional contexts (Hooge and Mark 2017; Klüver and Bäck 2019). Two complementary modeling strategies are employed. The first consists of OLS regressions estimating the association between radical right parliamentary presence and the ideological range of governing coalitions. The baseline specification includes the main independent variable and a limited set of predictors, while subsequent models introduce the full set of controls together with country fixed effects. The second strategy addresses potential endogeneity through a two-stage least squares (2SLS) design that instruments radical right parliamentary presence with radical right vote share. In the first stage, vote share predicts whether radical right parties obtain parliamentary representation. In the second stage, the predicted values of parliamentary presence are used to estimate the effect on coalition ideological range. Although this approach does not completely eliminate identification concerns, it provides a stronger basis for causal interpretation than purely observational models.

Empirical models, results and interpretation

The empirical analysis evaluates whether the parliamentary presence of radical right parties is associated with changes in the ideological composition of coalition governments. The main question is whether these parties widen the ideological scope of cabinets by constraining coalition options or whether their presence instead encourages more cohesive governing arrangements. In the initial OLS specification, radical right presence is positively and significantly associated with ideological range. At face value, this finding is consistent with the first hypothesis: cabinets appear more ideologically dispersed when a radical right party is represented in parliament. However, this bivariate association is limited in explanatory power

and likely affected by omitted variable bias. Once structural controls and country fixed effects are introduced, the result changes substantially. The coefficient for radical right presence becomes negative and loses statistical significance. This suggests that the positive association observed in the simpler model is not robust and is largely explained by broader structural characteristics of party systems and coalitions.

Table 1: Regression Results

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Ideological range of Cabinets		
	<i>OLS</i>	<i>instrumental variable</i>	
	(1)	(2)	
Constant	−0.493 (0.345)	0.557 (0.603)	1.319* (0.683)
Radical Right parties	1.544*** (0.461)	−0.082 (0.433)	−1.502** (0.711)
ENP	0.636*** (0.085)	−0.164* (0.095)	−0.479*** (0.154)
Polarization		0.231 (0.201)	0.288 (0.219)
Parties in cabinet		0.962*** (0.057)	0.968*** (0.058)
MWCs		−0.576*** (0.218)	−0.626*** (0.225)
Time variable		0.00002 (0.00002)	0.00003 (0.00002)
Radical Right parties and ENP	−0.389*** (0.104)	0.014 (0.105)	0.437** (0.190)
Observations	473	473	473
R ²	0.140	0.618	0.602
Adjusted R ²	0.135	0.588	0.571

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01
Country fixed effects included (coefficients omitted)

In the controlled model, the strongest and most consistent predictor of ideological range is cabinet size: larger coalitions are associated with broader ideological dispersion. Minimal winning coalitions, by contrast, are significantly narrower, which is in line with standard coalition theory. The effect of fragmentation also changes when controls are introduced. Whereas the simpler model suggests a positive relationship between ENP and ideological range, the fully specified model shows a negative and only marginally significant coefficient. This reversal indicates that once other relevant factors are held constant, fragmented systems may actually lead parties to form more selective governing coalitions rather than broader ones. In other words, fragmentation does not mechanically generate more ideologically diverse cabinets. The second hypothesis is evaluated through an interaction between radical right presence and ENP. Here, the results offer no support for the expectation. The interaction term does not reach statistical significance, indicating that the effect of radical right presence does not become stronger in more fragmented party systems. The theoretical intuition behind H2 is plausible, but it is not borne out empirically in these models.

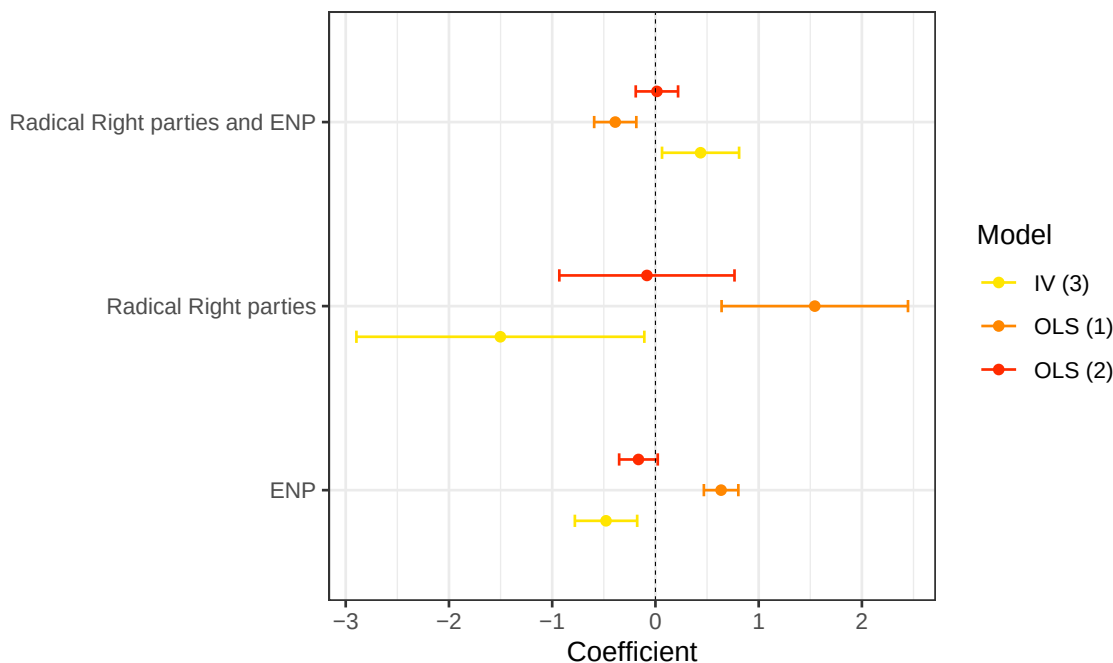


Figure 2: Effect Estimates Across the three Models

The final step of the analysis addresses endogeneity through the 2SLS specification. Once

radical right parliamentary presence is instrumented using radical right vote share, the estimated effect becomes negative and statistically significant. This is the most striking result in the paper because it directly contradicts the theoretical expectation in H3. Rather than widening the ideological range of coalition governments, radical right parliamentary presence appears associated with narrower and more cohesive cabinets. One possible interpretation is that mainstream parties react to radical right success by prioritizing unity and internal coherence. Faced with the electoral challenge posed by radical right actors, mainstream parties may prefer more compact governing arrangements that minimize conflict and present a clearer alternative. Under this interpretation, radical right presence does not produce ideologically broader coalitions through exclusion alone; instead, it may encourage strategic consolidation among governing parties. The control variables in the IV model behave similarly to those in the OLS specifications.

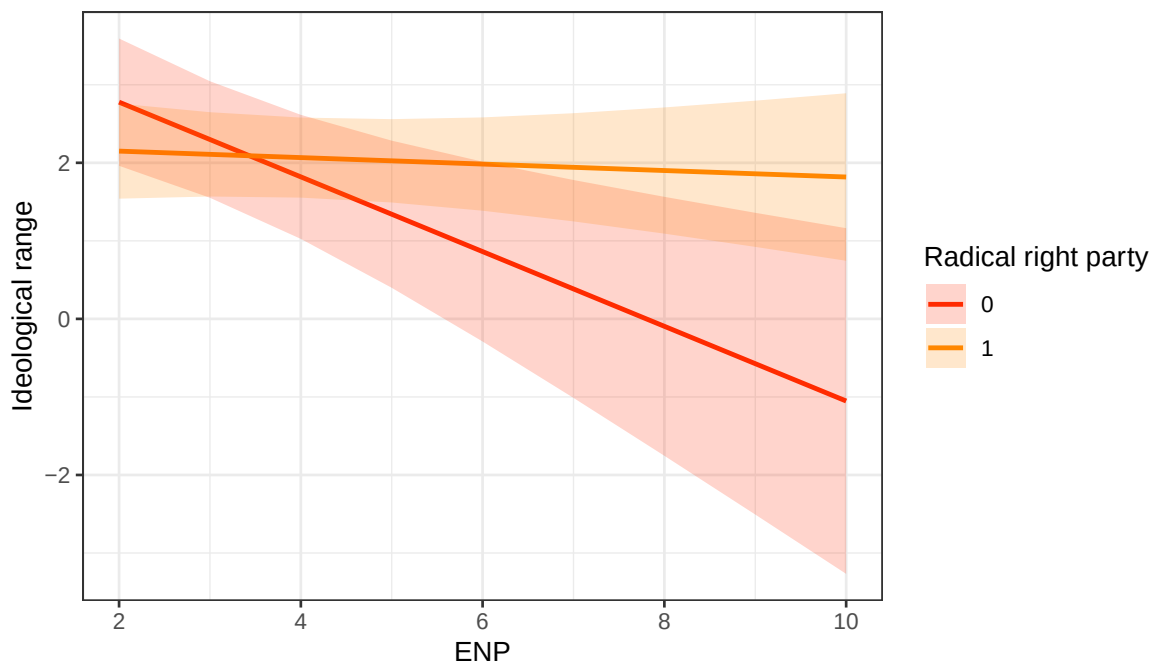


Figure 3: Presence-absence radical right parties in IV model

Cabinet size remains positively associated with ideological range, while minimal winning coalitions continue to predict narrower cabinets. Fragmentation becomes more clearly negative and statistically significant, reinforcing the idea that coalition ideological breadth is shaped

less by the number of parties in the system than by the strategic logic of cabinet formation. Country fixed effects also remain meaningful, indicating that national context continues to matter even after short-term shifts in party representation are taken into account. Taken together, the findings provide only limited support for the original argument. Hypothesis 1 receives support only in the simplest model and not in the more demanding specifications. Hypothesis 2 is not supported at all. Hypothesis 3 is contradicted by the IV analysis, which suggests an effect opposite to the one predicted. Overall, the evidence indicates that the ideological composition of coalition governments is shaped more by cabinet structure, coalition type, and institutional context than by the mere parliamentary presence of radical right parties.

Conclusion

This paper examined whether the parliamentary presence of radical right parties influences the ideological configuration of coalition governments across European parliamentary democracies. Drawing on theories of coalition formation and party system change, it proposed that radical right parliamentary entry would widen the ideological range of cabinets, especially in fragmented systems, and that this relationship would remain once endogeneity was addressed. The findings provide little support for these expectations. Although the bivariate models show a positive association between the presence of the radical right and the coalition's ideological range, this relationship disappears once structural controls and country fixed effects are included. The interaction with party system fragmentation is not statistically significant, providing no support for the idea that radical right presence has a stronger effect in more fragmented systems. Most importantly, the instrumental variable analysis suggests the opposite of the original expectation: once endogeneity is taken into account, radical right presence appears associated with narrower and more cohesive coalition governments. These results challenge the assumption that the rise of the radical right necessarily broadens the ideological boundaries of coalition governments. Instead, they suggest that coalition formation remains strongly shaped by arithmetic constraints, strategic bargaining, and institutional context. Radical right parties may still matter through other channels, including agenda-setting, electoral pressure, and indirect effects on mainstream party positioning (Brown, Mondon, and

Winter 2021; Müller, Bäck, and Hellström 2023), but their direct effect on coalition ideological range appears more limited than often assumed. More broadly, the paper contributes to the literature by shifting attention from the electoral success of radical right parties to their institutional consequences. At the same time, it underlines the value of addressing endogeneity when assessing those consequences, since simpler models may overstate or mischaracterize the effect of outsider parties. Future research could build on this analysis by using more dynamic ideological measures, incorporating qualitative evidence on coalition negotiations, or extending the comparison beyond Europe. Even in an era marked by polarization and radical right advance, the evidence here suggests that the mechanics of government formation remain more stable and selective than theories of disruption would predict.

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